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Riot police use water cannon on protesters during clashes over the government's ban on social media, outside the parliament building in Kathmandu, Nepal, yesterday.

19 killed as police in Nepal open fire on protesters

Home Minister resigns following violent protests against social media ban

KATHMANDU

Police in Kathmandu opened fire yesterday on protesters demonstrating against a government ban on social media, killing at least 17 and wounding 100 more, including policemen. Another two were killed during protests in Itahari City of Sunsari district. Nepal's Home Minister Ramesh Lekhak resigned yesterday evening following the deadly protests, citing moral responsibility for the loss of lives during demonstrations. During a cabinet meeting, Lekhak submitted his resignation to Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli, citing the violent suppression of demonstrators earlier in the day.

The district administration imposed a curfew in several key areas of the city, including the parliament, the president's residence and Singha Durbar, which houses the prime minister's office.

Several social media sites — including Facebook, YouTube and X — have been inaccessible in Nepal since Friday after the government blocked 26 unregistered platforms, leaving users angry and confused. Thousands took to the streets and were met with rubber bullets, tear gas, water cannon and baton-charges from police when the demonstrators pushed through barbed wire into a restricted area near parliament. “I have never seen such a disturbing situation at the hos-

pital,” said Ranjana Nepal, information officer at the facility which received many of those wounded. Nepali media reported police used live fire against the protesters. The district administration imposed a curfew in several key areas of the city, including the parliament, the president's residence and Singha Durbar, which houses the prime minister's office.

Corruption issue

Some demonstrators had climbed over the wall into the parliament premises and its gate was vandalised. Similar protests were organised in other districts across the country. “We were triggered by the social media ban but that is not the only reason we are gathered here,” said student Yujan Rajbhandari, 24. “We are protesting against corruption that has been institutionalised in Nepal.”

— Agencies
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Trump issues ‘last warning’ to Hamas

US PRESIDENT URGES PALESTINIAN GROUP TO ACCEPT HIS TRUCE TERMS

WASHINGTON

President Donald Trump said Hamas needs to accept his terms to end its war with Israel as he continues to press for an end to the fighting. “I have warned Hamas about the consequences of not accepting,” Trump wrote in a Truth Social post. “This is my last warning, there will not be another one!”

The post comes after Steve Witkoff, Trump's envoy to the Middle East, sent a new proposal last week to Hamas for a hostage and ceasefire deal through an Israeli peace activist, Axios reported, citing people with direct knowledge of the communication.

“The Israelis have accepted my Terms,” Trump wrote. “It is time for Hamas to accept as well.”

The proposed deal would include the release of all remaining hostages in exchange for ending the war in Gaza, Axios said.

‘Some ideas’

Meanwhile, Hamas said it received “some ideas” from US mediators in pursuit of a ceasefire and hostage release. But Hamas said that to agree to peace talks, it needed “a clear declaration” and Israeli commitment to ending the war and a full troop withdrawal from the Gaza Strip. It also expressed readiness

UAE CONDEMNATION

The UAE has strongly condemned the terrorist shooting near Jerusalem that left several people dead and others injured. In a statement, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) reiterated the UAE's firm rejection of all forms of violence and terrorism that threaten regional security and stability. The Ministry extended heartfelt condolences to the families of the victims and expressed solidarity with the state of Israel and its people. It also wished a swift recovery for the injured, stressing the UAE's consistent call for rejecting extremism in all its forms.

—WAM

to hand over control to a committee of independent Palestinian professionals. The statement did not address Israel's demands for the militant group to disarm. The US proposal is intended as a diplomatic effort to avert Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's planned large-scale offensive to seize Gaza City, where he promised a quick victory over Hamas, even as Israel's defence minister Israel Katz told Hamas yesterday to lay down its arms or face annihilation.

— Agencies
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Dubai Metro at 16: A humble start to record ridership

2024 closed with a record 275.4m passengers, averaging 900,000 daily riders

DUBAI

BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

From its humble beginnings in 2009 to a network carrying over 2.5 billion passengers, the Dubai Metro has changed the way people move, work, and live in Dubai. Today, on its 16th anniversary, the Metro stands as a symbol of innovation, operational excellence, and forward-thinking urban planning. With the Blue Line on the horizon, Dubai is ready to take the next leap, continuing to offer world-class transit solutions for decades to come. Over 16 years, the Metro has become much more than a transit system. It is a lifeline, a symbol of Dubai's ambition,



and a benchmark for operational excellence. With 99.7 per cent punctuality, the Metro has consistently delivered reliability, safety, and comfort, making it the preferred mode of transport for hundreds of thousands of commuters daily. Ridership tells the story of Dubai Metro's success. In 2010, it carried 38.8 million passengers. Just a year later, ridership surged 77 per cent to 69 million, a reflection of the city's rapidly growing population and increasing reliance on public transport. The year 2024 closed with a record 275.4 million passengers, averaging 900,000 daily riders.

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